

COLORADO RARE BIRD REPORT

RUDDY TURNSTONE
Arenaria interpres

Rcd 2/2/01 npl
7-0 (A)

Location: John Martin Reservoir; near Las Animas; Bent County, Colorado

Date: May 6, 2000

I found this bird on a small island just off the southwest shore of John Martin Reservoir. It was a rocky, pebbly point, ideal for this species. I observed the bird for about 10 minutes, in good light, from about 150 yards distance (with my Kowa scope at 20-60X). I never saw it in flight.

Description:

This was a breeding-plumaged bird. It was about 10" long, with moderately long legs. It was superficially most similar in size and aspect to the nearby Killdeer. It was reddish-brown above on the back and wings with a wide, black stripe through each folded wing. The head and face was white with a gray crown and was patterned black and white on the lower face. This pattern consisted of a black stripe down through the eye and across the lower face that curved and widened forward into a broad black bib on either side of the white breast. The rest of the underparts were white. The bill was rather short, only about half as long as the head, dark and wedge-shaped. The legs were medium-short, giving the bird a stubby look, and were bright orange.

Similar Species:

The medium size and bold white, black and rufous pattern eliminate most shorebirds. Avocets are much larger with recurved bills. Small and large plovers such as Snowy, Piping and Black-bellied lack the white face, bib, rufous and black back and wedge-shaped bill. The Killdeer is plainer above in flight and has two breast bands. Phalaropes have thinner and longer bills, different habits and lack orange legs. Sandpipers are plainer with less bold patterns and lack the wedged bill. Black Turnstone has no rufous and the head is not largely white.

Experience with Species:

I have seen many Ruddy Turnstones elsewhere in the U.S. and several in Colorado.

This report is prepared from notes made after observation.

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